Benefit sharing and perceived fairness in community-based ecotourism

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1. Introduction

Community-based ecotourism is often justified by the benefits it returns to the host community. Whether those benefits are perceived as fairly shared is a separate question, and the one this study addresses.

2. Methods

We surveyed 420 residents across three villages adjacent to a protected area. Perceived fairness of benefit distribution was measured with a five-item scale. Support for further tourism development was the outcome.

The study is observational. Data were collected in a single wave during 2017.

3. Findings

Perceived fairness explained 31% of the variance in support for further tourism development. The relationship was positive and statistically significant.

Residents employed directly in tourism reported higher perceived fairness than those who were not, but the difference narrowed once village of residence was taken into account.

4. Limitations

Self-reported fairness may reflect general satisfaction rather than any specific distribution of benefits.